

Self-Presentation Strategies on Airbnb in Response to the Paris 2024 Olympic Games

Ye Liu¹

Under the supervision of Christophe Bénavent (Dauphine-PSL) and Thierry Poibeau (ENS-PSL)

¹École nationale des chartes-PSL (France) Contact: ye.liu@chartes.psl.eu

CONTEXT



Worldwide Olympic Partner

Host the World

Shock: Paris 2024 Olympic Games as an exogenous shock, increasing tourism demand, new listings, and market competition.

Platform: Beyond Airbnbs built-in reputation system, hosts rely on self-presentation to reduce information uncertainty and signal trust and quality.

Response: Under competitive pressure, hosts strategically adjust self-presentation tactics to increase attractiveness and visibility.

DATA

Source: Inside Airbnb

Geographic coverage: Paris vs London

Temporal panels:

- **Pre-shock:** 2023-06, 2023-12
- **Post-shock:** 2024-06

Scale: 266,852 listings in total



Self-presentation tunnels:

- **Visual:** profile photo (95% available)
- **Textual:** host bios (50% available)

CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

Drawing on Goffmans **self-presentation** and **impression management theory**, we identify common self-presentation tactics in the Airbnb context as the basis for subsequent quantitative operationalization.

Textual	Description
Openness	Inclusive, cosmopolitan
Authenticity	Personal lifestyle disclosure
Sociability	Interaction and communication
Self-promotion	Provide service of quality
Exemplification	Compliance with norms

Visual	Description
Portrait	Face-centered image with clean background
Lifestyle	Host in social/daily context
No-person	No visible face

- [1] Goffman, E. (1959). *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*. Routledge.
- [2] Jones, E. E., & Pittman, T. S. (1982). *Toward a Theory of Strategic Self-Presentation.*, Psychological Perspectives on the Self, 231–262. Erlbaum, Hillsdale, NJ.

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MEASUREMENT PIPELINE FOR SELF-PRESENTATION TACTICS

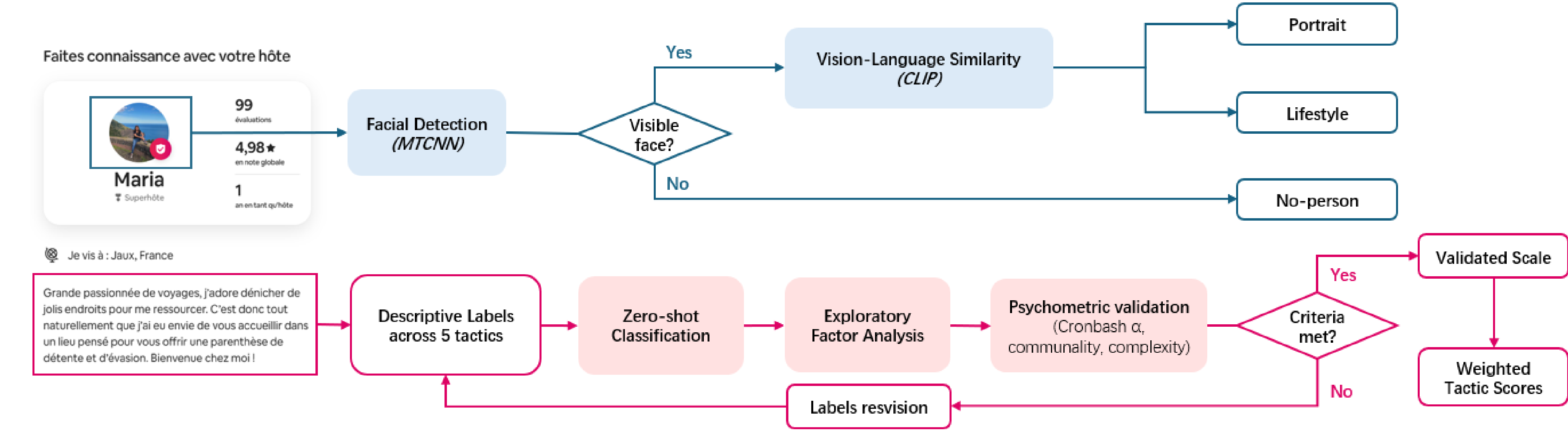
Visual tactics: Profile images are first processed using MTCNN for face detection. Images without detected faces are classified as *No-person*. For images containing faces, **CLIP** embeddings are used to compute image–text similarity with predefined label sets, enabling the distinction between *Portrait* and *Lifestyle* photos.

Textual tactics: We first construct descriptive labels grounded in the Airbnb context. An multilingual **zero-shot classification model** (*MoritzLaurer/bge-m3-zeroshot-v2.0*) is then used to

estimate the degree to which each label is expressed in host descriptions, producing semantic alignment scores.

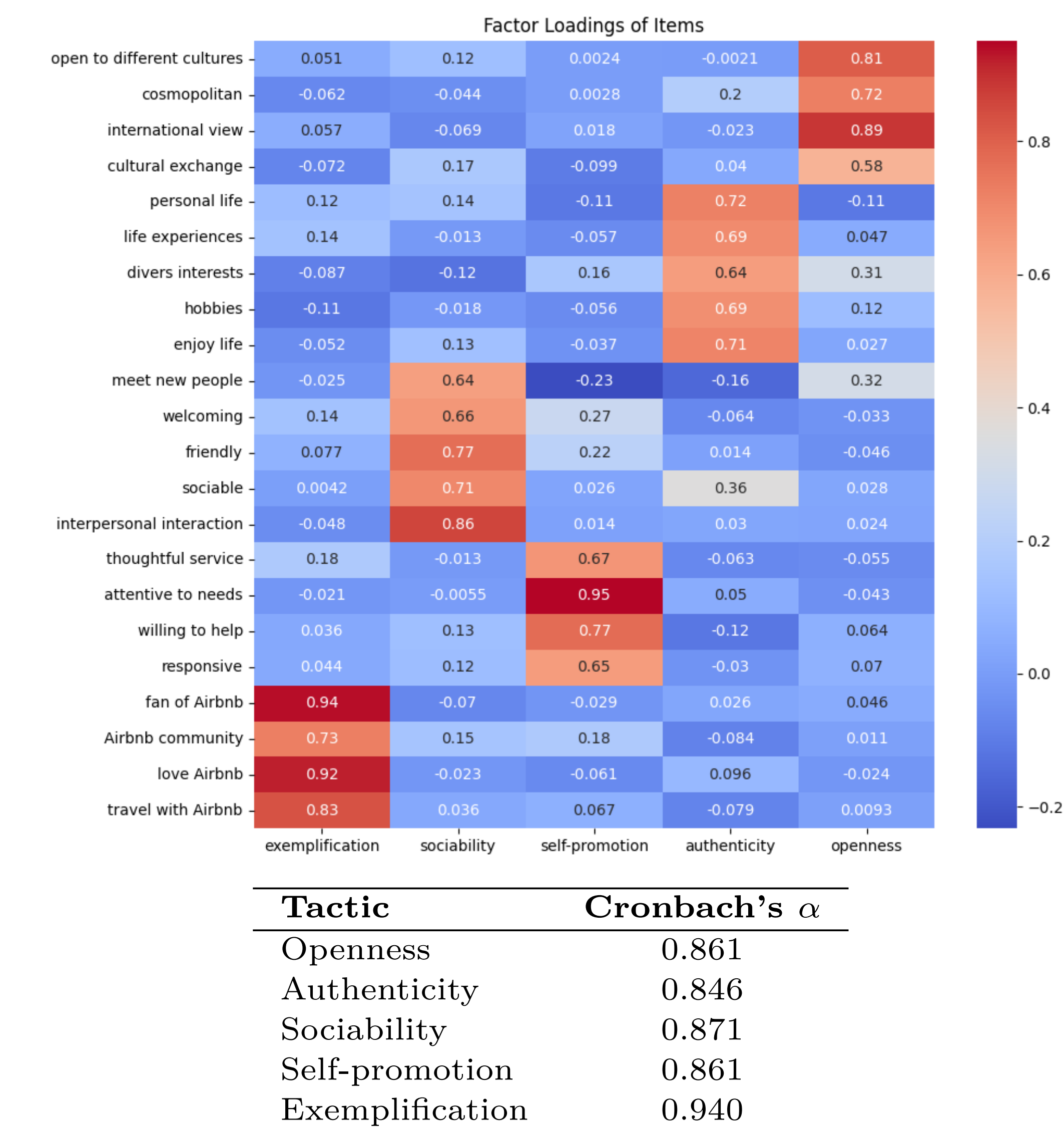
Measurement quality is iteratively evaluated on a pilot sample using **exploratory factor analysis (EFA)** and psychometric indicators (communality, complexity and Cronbachs α).The validated scale is subsequently applied to the full dataset to compute factor-loading-weighted tactic scores.

For hosts without a bio, tactic scores are set to 0 and a binary *has_text* indicator is included.



[1] Lee, S.-J. et al. (1999). *Development of a Self-Presentation Tactics Scale*, Personality and Individual Differences, 26(4), 701–722.

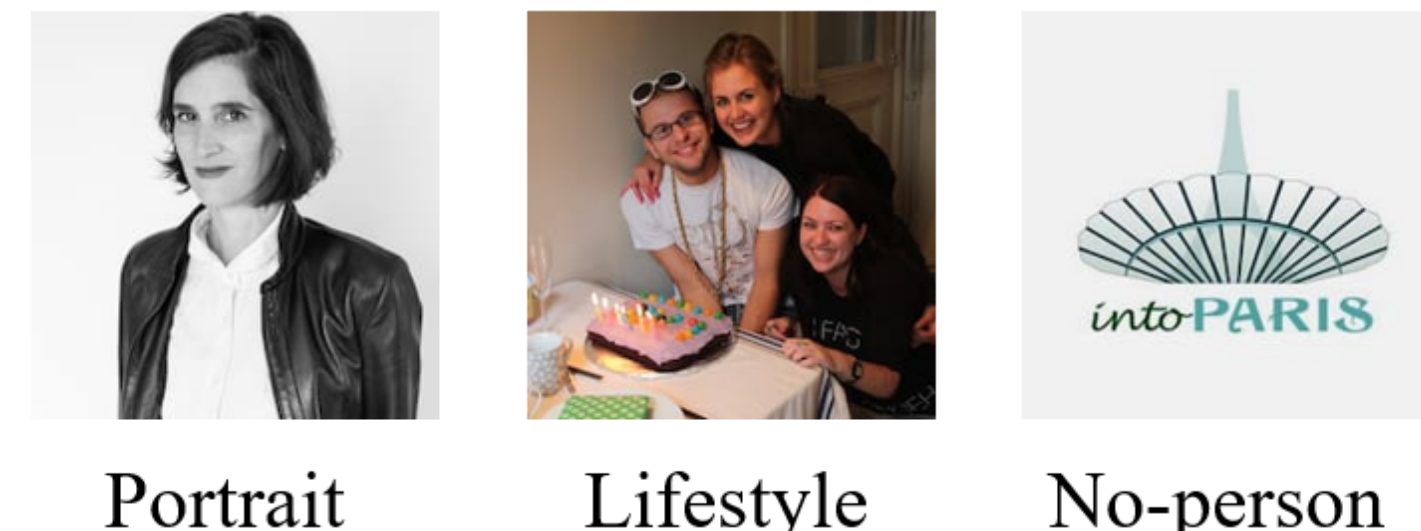
TACTIC MEASUREMENT: STRUCTURE AND RELIABILITY



EFA confirms a stable five-factor structure for textual self-presentation tactics, with strong loadings (generally > 0.64 , up to 0.95) and no substantial cross-loadings. Most items show satisfactory communality (> 0.5) and low-to-moderate complexity (1–2, indicating clear factorial structure). Reliability is high (Cronbachs $\alpha = 0.84–0.92$), supporting the validity of the **22-item measurement scale**.

At the tactic level, a two-dimensional factor structure emerges from the tactic scores, separating **relational** tactics (openness, authenticity, sociability) and **promotional** ones (self-promotion, exemplification).

Profile photo categories are illustrated below.

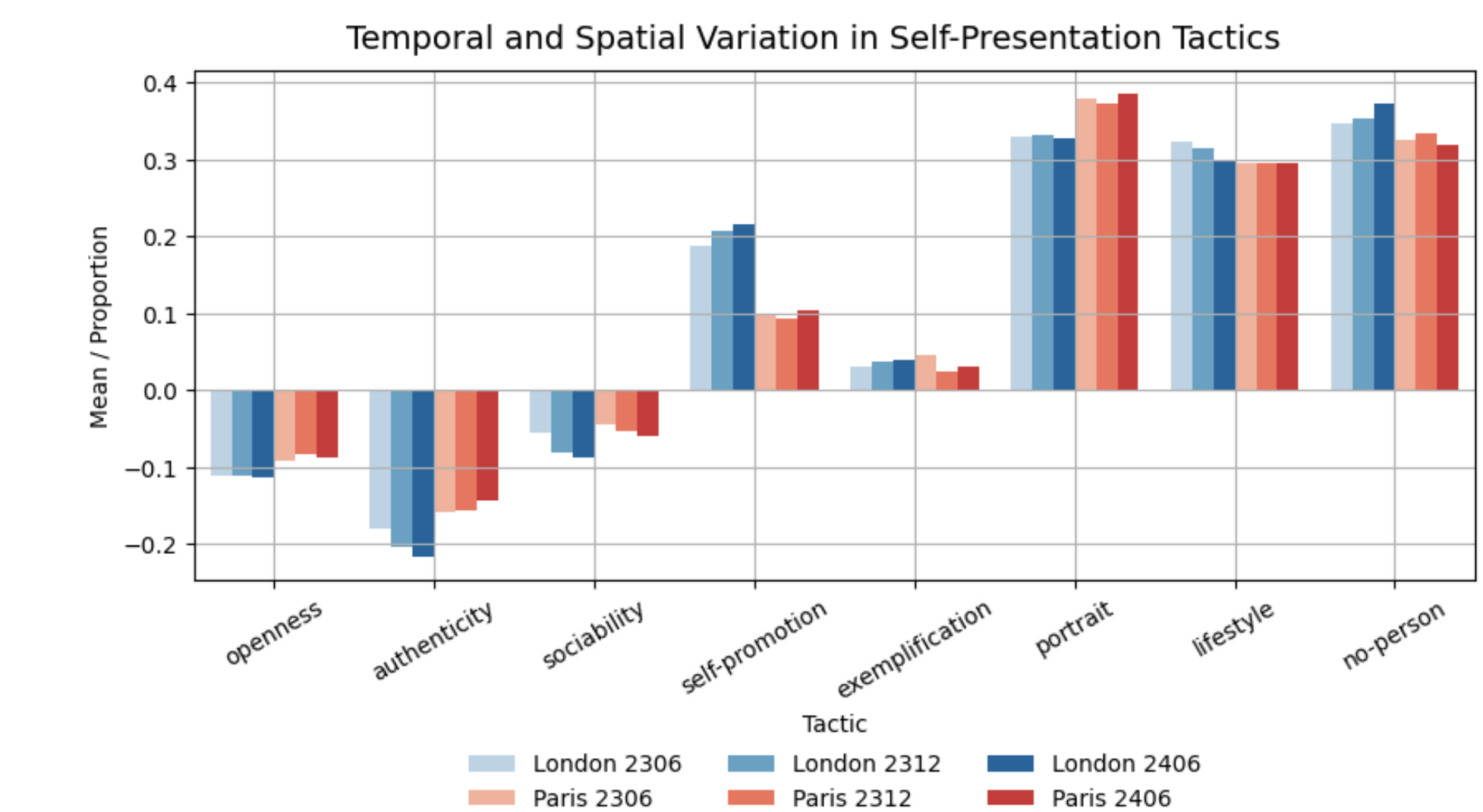


HOST RESPONSES TO THE OLYMPIC SHOCK

Descriptive statistics: Promotional tactics are more prevalent than relational ones, especially in London.

Profile photos are relatively balanced across categories, with portraits more common in Paris and no-person images more frequent in London.

Modeling results: We estimate an **OLS difference-in-differences** model with city and period interactions. The Olympic effect is defined as $\beta_{2406} - \beta_{2312}$.



- **Overall:** Most tactics respond significantly to the Olympic shock, indicating hosts' sensitivity to external market changes.
- **Textual:** Promotional tactics adjust more strongly than relational ones.
- **Visual:** Humanised profile photo shares increase more in Paris relative to London, while no-person images decline.
- **Pattern:** Under increased competition, hosts adopt more direct and visible self-presentation strategies to build trust more efficiently.

